

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 8

New Case: Aryan (24 y/o) – PTSD after Road Accident
Highly Detailed – Realistic Style

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	Aryan (24 years, Male, Software Engineer, Kochi)	Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	8 of 17	Focus:	Stabilization + Preparation for Processing

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client arrived looking tired but slightly more engaged than last session. He completed symptom monitoring on 6 out of 7 days and practiced all current tools. He reported 3 nightmares this week and several daytime intrusions. He continues to avoid driving completely and remains socially withdrawn. Today's plan: Review homework with compassion, explore the impact of PTSD on self-worth and daily functioning in more depth, continue stabilization, continue gentle preparation for trauma processing (assessing readiness without pressure), and assign manageable homework. Maintain gentle, non-pressuring pace.

SESSION START – HOMEWORK REVIEW

Therapist: Good morning, Aryan. How has your week been? I see you brought the notes again. How did all the tools go this week?

Client: (speaking in a low, tired voice) Breathing helped after nightmares. Safe Place still works better when I'm not too overwhelmed. The mental safe helped a bit with the guilt during the day. Progressive Muscle Relaxation helped me fall asleep faster on some nights. Cold water grounding helped me feel more awake and present after waking from nightmares. I had 3 nightmares this week. Intrusions during the day were mostly triggered by traffic sounds and seeing trucks. I still haven't driven at all.

Therapist: Thank you for practicing all the tools and for tracking everything so consistently. You're building real skills. How has the ongoing exhaustion been affecting how you see yourself and your work this week?

Client: I'm still making mistakes at work. I zone out during meetings. My manager asked me again if everything is okay. I told him I'm seeing someone for sleep issues. He was understanding, but I could tell he's concerned. I feel like I'm becoming the "problem employee." I also haven't replied to most of my friends' messages. I just don't have the energy to pretend I'm fine. I feel like I'm letting everyone down — at work, with friends, and with Rahul's memory.

EXPLORING IMPACT ON SELF-WORTH (CONTINUED)

Therapist: You mentioned again feeling like you're becoming the "problem employee" and that you're letting everyone down — including Rahul's memory. That sounds incredibly painful and heavy. The combination of trauma symptoms, exhaustion, avoidance, and guilt seems to be creating a very harsh view of yourself right now. Does that match what you're experiencing?

Client: Yeah. I used to be someone who worked hard and was reliable. Now I feel like I'm falling apart and everyone can see it. And the guilt about Rahul makes it worse — like I don't even deserve to be okay because he's not here.

Therapist: That combination — feeling like you're falling apart while also believing you don't deserve to be okay — is incredibly painful. The guilt is telling you that you shouldn't recover, while the trauma symptoms are making recovery harder. Both are very common after this kind of loss. You're not weak or broken for feeling this way. You're carrying an enormous amount. We can work gently with both the symptoms and the harsh self-view over time. For now, I want to acknowledge how exhausting and lonely this must feel.

Client: (quietly) It is. I don't talk about it because it feels selfish. Like I should just be grateful I survived.

Therapist: That thought — that you should just be grateful you survived — is also very common in survivor guilt. It doesn't mean it's true or helpful. You're allowed to struggle. You're allowed to need support. Carrying everything alone often makes the symptoms and the self-criticism worse, not better. We don't have to change how much you share with others right now. But we can keep looking at ways to be a bit kinder to yourself while you heal.

GENTLE PREPARATION FOR TRAUMA PROCESSING (CONTINUED)

Therapist: Last session we talked gently about the possibility of eventually working with the trauma memories more directly. You said you might be willing someday but not yet. Has anything changed in how you feel about that this week?

Client: (after a long pause) I still don't want to talk about the accident in detail. It still feels too much. But I guess I'm a bit more open to the idea that it might help someday. Just not now. I still need more time.

Therapist: Thank you for being honest. That's a very realistic and understandable place to be. We can keep focusing on stabilization and coping for as long as you need. There's no rush. We only move toward processing the memories when you feel ready and when we both agree it's the right time. You're in complete control of the pace.

Client: Okay. That helps. I don't feel as pressured.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week:

1. Continue tracking nightmares and flashbacks (numbers + intensity)
2. Practice diaphragmatic breathing when anxious or after nightmares
3. Practice Safe Place imagery once a day when relatively calm

4. Use the mental safe (containment) when guilt feels overwhelming during the day
5. Practice Progressive Muscle Relaxation (short version) when tense or before bed
6. Try cold water grounding when waking from nightmares or feeling dissociated

Client: I'll keep practicing all of them. They're starting to feel more natural.

Therapist: That's great to hear. You're building real skills.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we reviewed your week, explored how PTSD and guilt are affecting your self-view and daily life, and continued the gentle conversation about eventually moving toward trauma processing when you're ready. How are you feeling about today's session?

Client: It was okay. Talking about eventually processing the memories felt scary but also a bit relieving because you said there's no pressure. I still feel tired and guilty a lot, but having more tools helps a bit.

Therapist: That's completely fair. Any questions before we finish?

Client: Not really.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client continues to experience frequent nightmares and intrusions. Avoidance of driving and social withdrawal remain strong.
- Client showed realistic openness to eventually moving toward trauma processing but clearly stated he is still not ready. This was respected without pressure.
- All current coping tools are being used with increasing consistency.
- Stabilization phase continues. Gentle preparation for processing phase is ongoing.
- Next session: Review all coping tools, continue exploring impact of PTSD on functioning and self-worth, continue gentle preparation for processing if client remains open, introduce more self-soothing or grounding techniques if helpful.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.